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ABOUT THE SERIES

The Anchored Parenting Series

Each book in the series takes one part of family life and turns it into steady, practical tools you can use at home. Book 2, *Know Yourself as a Parent*, turns the lens inward: your goals, your stress style, your own story, and the steps to heal old wounds so you can parent on purpose.

START HERE

01 Welcome

Most parenting books start with the child. This one starts with you. The way we parent is shaped by what we hope for, what stresses us, how we were raised, and the parts of ourselves we learned to protect along the way. When we understand those things, we can respond to our children on purpose instead of on autopilot.

This workbook gathers the reflection tools from the Anchored Parenting Curriculum: goal-setting questions, a parent rating scale, a look at how you spend time with your child, the parenting styles we fall into under stress, and a guided look back at your own childhood. It ends with five steps for healing old wounds and parenting more consciously.

> **You can't give your child what you haven't yet found in yourself. Knowing yourself is where steady parenting begins.**

KEY IDEA

How to use this workbook

- Go slowly. Some sections take a few minutes; others may take a few days of thinking.
- Write your answers down. Patterns are easier to see on paper than in your head.
- Be honest and kind with yourself. These tools are for understanding, not for grading.
- Bring your answers to your counselor or parenting group if you are working with one.
- Revisit the scales every few months to notice how you are growing.

KEY IDEA

Take care of yourself as you go

Looking back at childhood can stir up strong feelings. That is normal and it is part of healing. If a question feels like too much, skip it, take a break, and come back later or work through it with a therapist. If you are ever in crisis, call or text **988** (Suicide and Crisis Lifeline) or text **HOME to 741741**.

02

SECTION 1 · EXPLORATION OF YOUR PARENTING ROLE

Get to Know You

Before we can change how we parent, we need a clear picture of where we are and where we want to go.

Your goals

1. What are your parenting goals?

2. How would you like your relationship with your child to grow?

3. What would you like to understand more about in parenting?

How you see yourself

4. How would your child describe you in three adjectives?

5. What three words describe the parent you strive to be?

6. What do you delight in about your child?

7. What are your strengths as a parent?

8. How do you want your child to remember you as their parent growing up?

Your hardships

9. What is hard about being a parent for you?

10. What are your signs of stress overload?

11. How do you balance the different roles you play?

12. What do you do for self-care?

SECTION 1 · EVALUATION TOOL

03 Parent Rating Scale

Every parent finds some parts of parenting easier than others. This scale helps you see where you feel steady and where you could use more support.

Rate each item from **0** (no difficulty) to **10** (highest level of difficulty). Go with your first, honest answer.

WORKSHEET

Parent rating scale

How hard is it for me to...	Rating (0–10)
1. Set boundaries with my child	
2. Have physical, nurturing contact with my child (eye contact, hugs)	
3. Figure out what my child is feeling at any given time	
4. Figure out what my child needs at any given time	
5. Help my child when they are hurt	
6. Help my child when they are angry	
7. Help my child when they are scared	
8. Help my child when they are sad	
9. Calm myself down when my child is acting out	
10. Set boundaries with my child when I am not feeling good	
11. Deal with my own worries and problems	
12. Allow my child to explore the world safely on their own	
13. Trust my child	
14. Trust my ability to communicate and work through hard conversations with my child	
15. Support and nurture my child when they are not performing well or are underachieving	
16. Encourage freedom and spontaneity in my child	

How hard is it for me to...	Rating (0–10)
17. Play with my child	

KEY IDEA

Reading your results

- **Scores of 0 to 3** are areas of strength. Notice them and give yourself credit.
- **Scores of 4 to 6** are areas to keep an eye on, especially during stressful seasons.
- **Scores of 7 to 10** are your growth areas. Circle your top three; they are good places to focus your work in this series.

PAUSE AND REFLECT

Which three items did I rate the highest? What do they have in common?

Which items come easily to me? Where did I learn those skills?

SECTION 1 · EVALUATION TOOL

04 Quality of Interactions

Connection is built in ordinary moments. Looking at how our time is actually spent can be eye-opening.

Think about the interactions you have had with your child over the **last two weeks**. Using the menu below, estimate the percentage of time you and your child spent in each activity. Include only the activities that are part of your life and cross out the ones that are not. Your percentages should add up to about 100%.

WORKSHEET

Interaction menu

Activity	% of our time	Notes
Physical activity		
Play		
Nurturing touch		
Talking		
Doing homework		
Separate activities in the same place		
Giving instructions and orders		
Advice giving		
Arguments		
Fights		
No interaction		
Other:		

Make your chart

Turn your percentages into a simple pie chart. Draw a large circle and divide it into slices, one for each activity, sized by its percentage. Shade connecting activities (play, talking, nurturing touch, physical activity) in one color and correcting or conflict activities (instructions, advice, arguments, fights) in another.

WORKSHEET

Example

Activity	Example %
Giving instructions and orders	30%
Separate activities in the same place	25%
Talking	15%
Doing homework	10%
Arguments	10%
Play	5%
Nurturing touch	5%

In this example, more than half of the time together is spent on instructions or side-by-side but separate activities, and only 10% is spent on play and nurturing touch. Small changes, like ten minutes of play a day, can shift the whole picture.

PAUSE AND REFLECT

What surprised me about my chart?

Which slice would I most like to grow? Which would I like to shrink?

One small change I will make this week:

SECTION 1 · PARENTING STYLES

05 Your Parenting Style Under Stress

We all have a default way of reacting when stress runs high. Naming it is the first step to choosing something different.

The stress styles

Read each description and **circle the animal that most closely matches your style of parenting in times of stress.** Many parents see themselves in more than one.

WORKSHEET

The four stress styles

Style	What it looks like under stress
Rhino	Forceful. Pushes the child into activities or choices without considering their input, believing "I know best."
Hummingbird	Avoids conflict by "fluttering away." Becomes distant or preoccupied, diverts attention to other tasks, and avoids difficult conversations.
Ostrich	Disengaged or emotionally numb. Avoids necessary decisions and may refuse to acknowledge problems in the child's life, effectively "checking out."
Lioness	Overprotective, sometimes to the point of helicopter parenting. Tries to shield the child from any harm or failure by controlling every part of their world.

My stress style is most often: _____

It shows up most when: _____

The ideal styles

These two styles are what we are aiming for. Healthy parenting blends both: the warmth and calm of the St. Bernard with the guidance and flexibility of the Dolphin.

WORKSHEET

The ideal styles

Style	What it looks like
St. Bernard	Calm, patient and emotionally regulated. Responds to the child's needs with empathy, makes time for connection, and creates a soothing, safe environment. Calmness and connectedness are the name of the game.
Dolphin	Balanced. Leads with clear guidance while following the child's cues. Encourages the child to share opinions and make choices, which builds confidence and self-regulation.

PAUSE AND REFLECT

When I slip into my stress style, what is usually happening for me?

What would the St. Bernard or the Dolphin do in that same moment?

One St. Bernard or Dolphin move I can practice this week:

SECTION 2 · REPARENTING 101

06 Your Story Shapes Your Parenting

Our children often show us exactly where we still have room to grow. Understanding our own story helps us parent from choice rather than old patterns.

Why look back?

How we were cared for as children shapes how we connect, comfort and set limits as adults. Research on adult attachment shows that what matters most is not whether our childhood was perfect but whether we can make sense of it. Parents who have reflected on their story, including the painful parts, are better able to give their children a secure base.

The questions below are inspired by the Adult Attachment Interview, a research tool used to understand how childhood relationships shape adults. Take your time with them. Please give a detailed answer for each.

KEY IDEA

Take your time

These questions can bring up strong memories. You don't need to answer them all in one sitting. Skip anything that feels too painful for now, and consider working through it with a therapist.

Your early relationships

1. How would you describe your relationship with your parents when you were a child?

2. Choose five words or phrases that describe your relationship with your mother (or mother figure) during childhood. For each one, write a specific memory that shows it.

3. Choose five words or phrases that describe your relationship with your father (or father figure) during childhood. For each one, write a specific memory that shows it.

When you were upset

4. When you were upset as a child, what did you do?

5. Describe a time you were upset, hurt or ill as a child. How did your parents respond?

6. Were there times you felt rejected by your parents? How did you respond?

7. Were you ever separated from your parents as a child? How did you feel during those separations?

Loss and hard experiences

8. Have you lost a parent or another important person in your life? How did that loss affect you, and how did you cope at the time?

9. Were there frightening or overwhelming experiences in your childhood (for example, accidents, hospital stays or mistreatment)? You may describe them briefly or simply note that they happened.

10. How do you think these experiences affected your growing up or your relationship with your parents?

Looking back as an adult

11. How has your relationship with your parents changed since childhood? Are you close with them now?

12. Are there unresolved issues between you and your parents?

13. How do you think your early experiences shaped your adult personality and your relationships with friends or partners?

14. How do you see your parents now, as an adult? Has your view of them changed?

15. What are your feelings toward your parents today, and how would you describe your relationship with them?

16. If some of your memories feel positive and others painful, how do you make sense of both being true?

17. Why do you think your parents behaved the way they did when you were a child?

18. How have your early experiences shaped your views on closeness, attachment and independence?

You as a parent

19. How have these experiences influenced the way you relate to your own children?

20. How is your approach to parenting similar to or different from your parents' approach?

21. What do you hope for in your future relationship with your parents?

22. Is there anything else about your childhood or your relationship with your parents that feels important to write down?

SECTION 2 · PROTECTORS AND EXILES

07 Our Struggles Have Stories

The struggles we face as adults often began as smart ways a child found to stay safe and stay loved.

How our struggles begin

As children, we adapt to our environment. If making mistakes brought harsh criticism, we might have become perfectionistic to win back approval. If big feelings were met with anger, we might have learned to go quiet. These strategies helped us cope at the time.

Internal Family Systems (IFS) therapy describes this as a system of **parts**. Some parts, called **exiles**, hold the feelings and traits that were not accepted. Other parts, called **protectors**, work hard to keep those painful feelings from overwhelming us.

Without awareness, we can repeat these patterns with our own children. We may find ourselves shutting down traits in our child that were once shut down in us, passing the same emotional suppression to the next generation.

WORKSHEET

Try this

Write the sentence below and fill in the blank.

"I struggle with the _____ part of me. This struggle has a story."

Exiles

Exiles are the wounded parts of us that were pushed away in childhood because of pain, shame or fear. They hold painful memories and unresolved feelings, and protector parts work to keep them out of sight. Common exiles include:

- **The Not-Good-Enough Child**
- **The Helpless Child**
- **The Sensitive Child**
- **The Fearful Child**
- **The Unloved Child**

Protectors

Protectors guard against the pain and vulnerability we felt in childhood. They helped us survive, but as parents they may not always serve us or our children well. Common protector roles include:

1. **The Perfectionist Parent:** keeps everything (and everyone) under tight standards so no one can criticize.
2. **The Overprotective Parent:** tries to prevent any hurt or failure.
3. **The Dismissive Parent:** brushes off feelings that feel too big or uncomfortable.
4. **The Authoritarian Parent:** relies on control and obedience to feel safe.
5. **The Workaholic Parent:** stays busy so painful feelings don't catch up.

WORKSHEET

My parts

My protector parts	What they protect me from	My exile parts	What they need

PAUSE AND REFLECT

When does my strongest protector part show up with my child?

What might my exile part need to hear right now?

SECTION 2 · FIVE STEPS

08 Heal Those Childhood Wounds

You can't change your past, but you can change your present. Healing is a gradual process, and every step counts.

Five steps toward conscious parenting

1. **Parent consciously.** Start by noticing the behaviors and emotional patterns that show up in your parenting, especially during stress or conflict. Notice if you feel the urge to dismiss, control or withdraw.
2. **Use the pause button.** Remind yourself that your child is not the source of these feelings; they belong to your past. When you react strongly, pause and ask, "Is this really about my child, or is it about something in me?" This helps separate old wounds from the present moment.
3. **Wear your oxygen mask.** Parenting brings up old wounds, and it is common to feel guilt or frustration when you react in ways you don't want to. Practice self-compassion: you are doing the best you can with the tools you have. Make time for self-care that restores you and nurtures your exiled parts.
4. **Do your work.** Revisiting painful memories, with support, can be a path to healing. As you process your story, you may let go of anger, fear or resentment, and your interactions with your child can soften. When you show how you've worked through difficulty, you model resilience and emotional intelligence for your child.
5. **Commit daily.** Say to yourself each day, "I am a good parent." Simple daily affirmations increase motivation and make it more likely you'll follow through on value-based changes. Invite your family into the commitment: a sticky note on the fridge that says "We use kind words with each other" reinforces positive connection for everyone.

WORKSHEET

My pause question

When I feel myself reacting strongly, I will pause and ask myself:

_____

DAILY PRACTICE

Self-care that restores me

- [ ] Sleep and rest
- [ ] Movement or time outdoors
- [ ] Talking with a friend or support person
- [ ] Quiet time, prayer or meditation
- [ ] Counseling or a parenting group
- [ ] Something creative or fun just for me
- [ ] Other: _____

PAUSE AND REFLECT

Which of the five steps feels easiest for me? Which feels hardest?

What will I say to myself the next time I react in a way I regret?

09

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

My Know-Yourself Plan

Bring together what you've learned about yourself so you can return to it on the hard days.

WORKSHEET

My plan

Area	What I learned about myself	What I want to practice
My goals		
My growth areas (rating scale)		
My time with my child		
My stress style		
My story		
My protector and exile parts		
My self-care		

My commitment: As a parent, I want to be _____,
_____ and _____.

WORKSHEET

Check back in

Date	Re-rate my top 3 growth areas	What has changed

TOOLKIT

10 Quick Reference

Small reminders for the moments when old patterns show up.

KEY IDEA

When I feel triggered

- Pause and take three slow breaths.
- Ask, "Is this about my child, or about something in me?"
- Name what I feel: "I'm feeling overwhelmed right now."
- Choose the St. Bernard or the Dolphin response.
- Repair if I slip: "I'm sorry I yelled. Let's try again."

WORKSHEET

Words that help me

When I notice...	I can say to myself...
I'm being too hard on myself	"I'm doing the best I can with the tools I have."
An old wound is stirred up	"This feeling is from my past. My child is safe, and so am I."
I want to control or withdraw	"I can stay present and still hold the limit."
I made a mistake	"Repair matters more than perfection."
I'm running on empty	"Taking care of myself helps me take care of my child."

KEY IDEA

Getting support

If you are in crisis or thinking about harming yourself, call or text **988** (Suicide and Crisis Lifeline) or text **HOME to 741741** (Crisis Text Line). For counseling support, contact Anchored Inside Counseling Services or a licensed therapist in your area.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Adapted from the Anchored Parenting Curriculum by Jessica Prosser, LPC, written in original language. Reflection prompts are inspired by the Adult Attachment Interview (George, Kaplan & Main) and by Internal Family Systems (Schwartz, R. C., *No Bad Parts*, Sounds True, 2021). Related reading: Tsabary, S., *The Conscious Parent* (Namaste, 2010); Siegel, D. J. & Hartzell, M., *Parenting from the Inside Out* (TarcherPerigee, 2014). Not affiliated with or endorsed by these authors.